on the Dunkel proposals, as well as on the larger debates about globalisation, liberalisation and privatisation. In this, the economic conservatives within the BJP found ready allies among the Left's trade unions. The RSS, in its economic thinking at least, was much closer to the Left than any other political formation in India.

As RSS ideologue Rakesh Sinha, a nominated Rajya Sabha MP since 2018, wrote in 2001, 'Yesterday's Right has become today's Left. The RSS has been accused as pro-United States and "Right-reactionary" by the Indian Left and Nehruvians who must now be dumbfounded by radical ideological overtures of the RSS which is appealing to the Left trade unions to join hands against the hegemonic politics of America and the capitalist economic order … A traditional watertight compartmentalisation of politics and elites between the Right and the Left has harmed the country in evolving a realistic path of economic development.'[75] In economic terms at least, it was left-of-centre.

The BJP's initial suspicion of the reforms was not too dissimilar to the critique offered by what came to be known as the Bombay Club: a group of leading Indian industrialists who, in the early 1990s, argued that a rapid opening up of the Indian economy would hurt domestic industry since it suffered from several handicaps.[76] In his presidential address in Bangalore in 1994, Advani said, 'Government's impassioned advocacy of globalisation often smacks of diffidence and helplessness … We cannot shut ourselves from the rest of the world but we have to be careful to see that we are not swamped by the world either.'[77]

This approach enabled the BJP to end the initial isolation it had faced with the hard cultural nationalism of the Ram Temple movement. It allowed the party to mobilise those who had been left out or felt threatened by the reforms process, including leading Indian businessmen. By 1993, it had emerged as the 'new darling of industrialists'. More businessmen began 'putting money on the party than ever before'. Some were investing in a political formation that they saw as a rising force: '*Jis taraf hawa ka rukh hai ham usee taraf jhuk jaate hai* [where the wind is blowing, we bend that way],' a businessman told a leading magazine in 1993.[78] Some business leaders saw the BJP as a useful ally in articulating their concerns on